traditional role was to blow the conch and chant verses in Tamil.

6 According to press reports in December 2015, what is believed to be a sixth-century version has been discovered tucked into a *purana* in the library of the Asiatic Society of Bengal, Kolkata. This would make it by far the oldest extant version, although no formal announcement has been made to date.

7 William Carey and Joshua Marshman, *The Ramayuna of Valmeeki, in the original Sungskrit, with a prose translation and explanatory notes,* 1806-10.

8 In recent years this line 'Mahendra, planted in the sea' has been taken literally by some, who see it as further evidence of the Great Inundation.

9 R. T. H. Griffith, *The Ramayana of Valmiki*, Book IV, Canto 41, 1870-75.

10 Nachinarkiniyar, *Payiram,* Porul. 34.

11 K. R. Subramanian, *The origin of Saivism and its history in the Tamil land*, 1929.

12 Quoted in E. F. Irschilk, *Politics and social conflict in South Asia: the non-Brahmin movement and Tamil separatism 1916-19*, 1969.

13 No direct reference to Agastya exists in Sangam literature, but much has been made in recent years of one ambiguous word in Poem 201 of the *Purananuru* discussed earlier, in which its composer praises a Velir ruler of Kodumbalur (between Madurai and Tiruchirappalli) named Irungovel*, 'slayer of tigers',* whose dynasty is descended from Lord Krishna. He refers to him as a descendant of forty-nine generations of Velirs whose ancestor ruled over a distant walled city called Turuvai and who sprang from the *tadavu* of a 'northern sage'. That word *tadavu* is usually translated as 'pit', as in a ceremonial fire-pit, but with some stretching can be read as a 'clay pitcher', which would identify this 'northern sage' as Agathya.